European Commission

Community-Led Local Development and the Blue Economy

The Blue Economy encompasses all industries and sectors related to the EU's seas, inland waters, and coastlines. Under the European Maritime, Fisheries and Aquaculture Fund (EMFAF), 2021-2027, coastal areas have the opportunity to support Community-Led Local Development (CLLD) through Local Action Groups (LAGs) with a particular focus on fostering the sustainable Blue Economy.

LAGs funded under the EMFAF should ensure communities in fisheries and aquaculture areas better exploit and **benefit from the opportunities offered by the Blue Economy**, capitalising on and strengthening natural, cultural, social, and human resources in their areas.

TOWARDS A SUSTAINABLE BLUE ECONOMY

Contributing to the European Green Deal and the EU's Recovery Strategy is a new approach for a sustainable Blue Economy in the EU.

The approach promotes a sustainable, resilient, and climate-neutral model for a Blue Economy based on decarbonisation, circularity, conservation, climate adaptation and sustainable food production. In 2019, it was estimated that the EU's Blue Economy directly employed close to 4.45 million people and generated €667.2 billion in turnover.[1]

This includes:

- **Established sectors** such as marine and freshwater living and non-living resources, marine renewable energies, port activities, shipbuilding and repair, maritime transport, and coastal tourism.
- **Emerging and innovative sectors** including ocean energy, biotechnologies, desalination, maritime defence, security and surveillance, and maritime infrastructure.

(1) European Commission (2021). The EU Blue Economy Report. Publications Office of the European Union. Luxembourg.

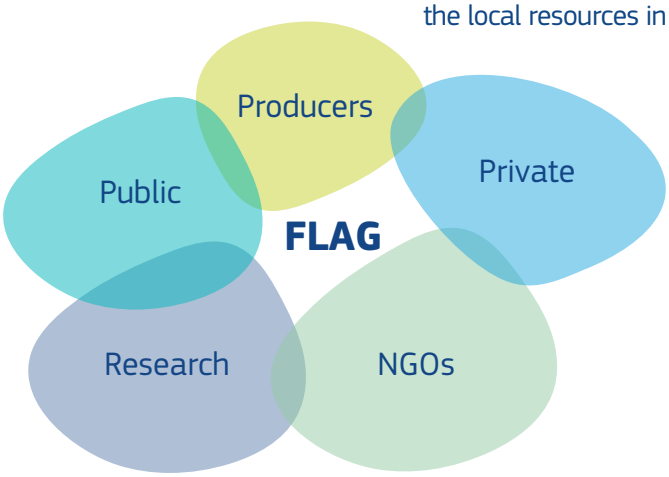
Laying the foundations of the Blue Economy through CLLD

As local groups that bring together stakeholders from different sectors, fisheries LAGs are uniquely placed to support the transition to a sustainable Blue Economy. They can help stimulate innovative, collective, and territorial projects and, through facilitating networking, can increase the consistency of local actions and policies. CLLD can therefore, play a crucial role in the development of Blue Economy sectors by combining the regeneration of aquatic resources with the preservation of local livelihoods.

By balancing an **area's natural capital and resources with the interests of several stakeholder groups**, fisheries LAGs can foster synergies between stakeholders and lay a vision and strategy for developing a sustainable Blue Economy.

Things to consider when developing your LAG strategy:

- No two areas are the same in terms of their natural capital, resources, and Blue Economy potential. **Consider which elements of the Blue Economy are most applicable to your area.**
- Fisheries LAG partnerships should i**nvolve the key organisations and individuals relevant to your area's Blue Economy,** including the fisheries and/or aquaculture sectors.
- Under the EMFAF, your **local development strategy should help communities benefit from the opportunities offered by the Blue Economy,** capitalising on and strengthening the local resources in your territory.



Key areas of the Blue Economy for fisheries LAGs

GREENING PORT INFRASTRUCTURES AND DECARBONISATION

Bring businesses together in your area to focus on energy use and decarbonisation – or support your key Blue Economy sectors to join existing efforts. This is what the Sotavento do Algarve fisheries LAG did when it helped its aquaculture producers transition to solar power.

The EU aims to be carbon neutral by 2050. Fisheries LAGs can support this objective by working towards reducing their areas' dependency on fossil fuels through innovation in energy efficiencies and renewable energies. Fisheries LAGs can foster collaborative actions related to renewable energies by bringing different stakeholders together in concerted efforts. Ports and harbours are crucial for connectivity. The infrastructure of ports and smaller harbours play an important role in fostering a sustainable Blue Economy, acting as a hub for many "blue sectors".

LAGs can focus their efforts on the greening of ports and harbours in their areas, for example:

Your local development strategy does not have to focus on large-scale initiatives related to the greening of port infrastructures. Several smaller initiatives across multiple areas can have a large, combined effect on developing greener, more sustainable port activities in your area.

- **Industry clusters:** ports and harbours are ideal locations for developing collaboration between industries (e.g., Iceland Ocean Cluster) and co-working spaces which can bring the Blue Economy sectors together, foster collaboration and networking, and attract new start-ups working on innovative sectors (e.g., Marstal Engine Factory, Denmark).
- **Renewable energy hubs:** offshore wind energy is a prominent industry, but there are many emerging technologies that fisheries LAGs can also help develop in their areas, such as: ocean, solar, tidal, hydropower, and bioenergy.
- **Smart solutions to shipping and transportation** (e.g., autonomous systems) can provide key tools for optimising traffic and cargo handling, while also providing better working conditions for operators and improved living conditions for local communities.
- **Circular economy:** fisheries LAGs can be instrumental in supporting more circular production processes and connecting local businesses to develop waste management solutions, including the reuse and recycling of marine plastics. For more information, see FARNET Guide 17: Circular Economy in fisheries and aquaculture areas.

SUSTAINABLE FOOD PRODUCTION AND THE CONSERVATION OF LIVING RESOURCES

Marine and freshwater resources are crucial for food security in the EU. While the Blue Economy presents many new opportunities, fisheries and aquaculture are likely to remain at the heart of the strategies of many fisheries LAGs. As a prerequisite to sustainable fisheries and aquaculture, conservation activities will be fundamental among the projects that LAGs choose to support. Striking a balance between conservation and production activities is, therefore, essential to successfully achieving a sustainable Blue Economy.

Fisheries LAGs can focus on the following activities:

CONSERVATION

- Building knowledge and conducting research on the state of your area's natural resources.
- Working towards the use of selective fishing techniques and controls (e.g., digitalisation and the introduction of mobile technologies, innovation in fishing gears). For more information on digitalisation and mobile systems, see FARNET Guide 18: Smart Coastal Areas.
- Research on the current state of ecosystems, natural habitats, and marine protected areas (MPAs) in your area.
- Projects related to the restoration of natural ecosystems and biodiversity.
- Strengthening local resource management processes. For more information and practical examples, see FARNET Guide 16: Strengthening local resource management.
- Considering the carbon footprint of potential projects and offsetting measures.

PRODUCTION

- The valorisation of local products, traditions, and artisanal practices. For information on the valorisation and marketing of local products, see FARNET Guide 8: Marketing the local catch.
- Developing short fisheries and aquaculture supply chains and alternative food systems. See FARNET Guide 12: Boosting businesses along the fisheries supply chain.
- New product development (e.g., biotechnologies, cosmetics, innovation in the use of bycatches, pharmaceuticals, and in particular the use of algae).
- Making production practices and supply chains more circular (i.e., the Circular Economy). For a practical example on how local actors in a FLAG area can come together in more circular ways see Fil and Fab, France.
- New production systems, particularly those related to aquaculture (e.g., aquaponics, recirculating aquaculture systems [RAS], integrated multitrophic aquaculture [IMTA]). For practical examples on how you can integrate aquaculture in your local development strategy see FARNET Guide 14: Integrating aquaculture within local communities.

Fisheries LAGs can work on conservation initiatives such as the restoration of natural habitats which will have a positive impact on fish stocks and increased production. This can bring different stakeholders together in achieving common goals and mutual benefits to the area. For more information, see this practical example from the Stockholmsbygd fisheries LAG, Sweden, on reinstating coastal wetlands.

Traceability and data on production in your territory can be vital to developing conservation efforts and capitalising on a sustainable Blue Economy. Consider the role of local Universities and Research Centres in your partnership and how they can support your strategic objectives with data and knowledge. For an example of how using digital tools can enhance catch-data collection and traceability along the fisheries value chain see this example from the East Finland fisheries LAG.

OTHER BLUE ECONOMY ACTIVITIES, SUCH AS BLUE TOURISM

Tourism presents opportunities for fisheries LAGs in working towards a sustainable Blue Economy, and in forming connections and cohesion between Blue Economy sectors. In promoting the use of local resources, traditions and heritage, LAGs can work on developing Blue Tourism from which several stakeholder groups can benefit. Successful Blue Tourism requires a transition towards more sustainable local services and supply chains, and specifically local services and supply chain actors working together on local objectives.

Fisheries LAGs can focus, for example, on the following areas:

The development of **'slow tourism'**. Slow tourism emphasises a strategy aimed at attracting sustainability-conscious tourists. This includes promoting decarbonisation and sustainable modes of travel, short food supply chains and eating locally, as well as activities which focus on mindfulness, activities such as restoration (e.g., harbours and lighthouse), combatting marginalisation (i.e., inclusivity), ecological projects, and learning new skills.

Pesca-tourism can provide additional income to fishers and helps the visitors understand and appreciate fishing as a profession (i.e., taking visitors on an active fishing boat to watch fishing activities).

'Blue Care' is another approach and includes activities that promote physical and mental health and well-being through contact with nature, with a specific focus on activities associated with the coast and water.

Other actions may include **recreational fishing, hiking trails, scuba-diving, sailing,** and other water-based activities. LAGs might also focus on traditional practices such as net mending, promoting hands-on tourism projects focused on learning and sharing of traditional skills.

Focus on local, small businesses and how you can integrate them within your local development strategy related to tourism. Small-scale enterprises often produce local artisanal products which can bolster your area's tourism offering, particularly when focusing on slow tourism and sustainability objectives (i.e., slow food, lowering food miles, short food supply chains).

Consider the social impact of tourism in your area. CLLD tourism projects can increase social resilience through job creation and economic opportunities for coastal communities (see FARNET Guide 9: Fisheries and Tourism: Creating benefits for the community).

Maritime spatial planning in developing a sustainable Blue Economy

Organise regular meetings and working groups on selected topics related to MSP. Engage stakeholders in your area to achieve a participatory approach to your area's development strategy and trajectory and provide public information on local MSP issues in your territory.

The different activities mentioned above give an indication of the range and increasing number of Blue Economy sectors. However, as the space in which these activities take place is finite, the coordination and planning of activities is vital for a harmonious and sustainable Blue Economy.

Maritime Spatial Planning (MSP) is the process of bringing together multiple users of the ocean (including energy, industry, government, conservation, recreation, and tourism) to make coordinated and informed decisions about how to use an area's natural marine resources sustainably. As fisheries LAGs are integrated, multi-sectoral partnerships focused on their area's sustainable territorial development, they can help encourage the cooperation required for successful MSP, ensuring consistency between local development strategies and EU policy.

Fisheries LAGs represent a unique governance structure, including representatives from both the public and non-public sectors, that can bring the Blue Economy together. Based on a bottom-up approach, LAGs can provide a forum for dialogues between different Blue Economy stakeholders in order to strengthen their capacity, cooperation, and decision-making. Such forums and networking can often be crucial to avoiding conflicts and fostering collaboration in the MSP process.

Research and innovation is vital for development of a sustainable Blue Economy. Consider how your LAG can benefit from and contribute to research and innovation using smart specialisation (S3) through the EU's S3 Platform which provides information, methodologies, expertise, and advice, as well as promoting mutual learning and transnational cooperation.

SUPPORTING INNOVATION AND NEW BLUE START-UPS

Working towards a sustainable Blue Economy can involve the need for innovation and new start-up ventures. Fisheries LAGs can support entrepreneurs in the development of new technologies and practices related to Blue Economy sectors, particularly in building upon existing industry in the area. The identification of new opportunities can act as a basis for developing interventions within a fisheries LAG's local development strategy. LAGs should also consider social innovation, and how the Blue Economy can extend and strengthen civil society (e.g., creating better working conditions, education, health, and community development). LAG projects can bring together research institutes and local businesses and provide a forum for exchange and cooperation. These forums can nurture new ideas and in turn new start-ups and entrepreneurial activities, like the Blue Valley project (https://www.campusmer.fr/blue-valley-4544-0-0-0.html) from the Morlaix FLAG which facilitates the uptake of the research developed by a local marine research station (Roscoff https://www.sb-roscoff.fr/) by local businesses.

Further support

FAMENET is a specialised service contracted by DG MARE to support the implementation of the EMFAF; part of its responsibilities is **networking and capacity building of all stakeholders involved in the implementation of CLLD under the EMFAF.** If you have a question for FAMENET, please contact CLLD@famenet.eu. You can also follow FAMENET on Twitter and LinkedIn.

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